

**Dong quai**

A stout, erect perennial growing to 6½ ft (2 m), with large bright green leaves and hollow stems.

Angelica sinensis syn. *A. polymorpha* (Apiaceae)

Dong Quai, Chinese Angelica, Dang Gui (Chinese)

In China, *dong quai* is the main tonic herb for conditions suffered by women. It is taken on a daily basis by millions of women as an invigorating tonic, helping to regulate menstruation and tonify the blood. It also improves the circulation. *Dong quai* has a sweet, pungent aroma that is very distinctive, and in China it is often used in cooking, which is the best way to take it as a blood tonic.



Dong quai has attractive clusters of white flowers in summer.

Habitat & Cultivation

Dong quai is native to China and Japan, where it is now cultivated. The best rhizomes are in Gansu province in China. Seed is sown in spring and the rhizomes are lifted in autumn.

Related Species

American angelica (*A. atropurpurea*) has similar properties, though it is less aromatic. European angelica (*A. archangelica*, p. 168) is a warming tonic herb for digestion and circulation, but does not have the same tonic action as *dong quai*.

Key Constituents

- Volatile oil (ligustilide, sesquiterpenes, carvacrol)
- Coumarins
- Phytosterols
- Polyacetylenes
- Ferulic acid

Key Actions

- Tonic
- Anti-inflammatory
- Antispasmodic

- Thins blood
- Promotes menstrual flow

Research

- **Gynecology** Research in China from the 1970s has shown that the herb helps to regulate uterine contractions, which may explain its benefit for period pain.
- **Circulation** The root can help to normalize heart function and has been shown to thin the blood. It may therefore interact with anticoagulant medicines.

Traditional & Current Uses

- **Blood tonic** Famous in China as a tonic, *dong quai* is taken for “deficient blood” conditions, anemia, and for the symptoms of anemia due to blood loss—a pale complexion, palpitations, and lowered vitality.
- **Women’s health** *Dong quai* regulates the menstrual cycle, relieves period pain and cramps, and is an ideal tonic for women with heavy menstruation who risk becoming anemic. However, as it stimulates menstrual bleeding, other tonic herbs such as nettle (*Urtica dioica*, p. 146) are best taken during menstruation if the flow is heavy. It is also a uterine tonic, and helps infertility.
- **Circulation** *Dong quai* is a “warming” herb, improving the circulation to the abdomen and to the hands and feet. It strengthens the digestion and is also useful in the treatment of abscesses and boils.

Self-help Uses

- **Aiding conception**, p. 316.
- **Menstrual problems**, p. 315.

Parts Used

Rhizome is valued for its medicinal properties and is often used in cooking.

Sliced dried rhizome

Rhizome is large and brownish on the outside and white inside

Key Preparations & Their Uses

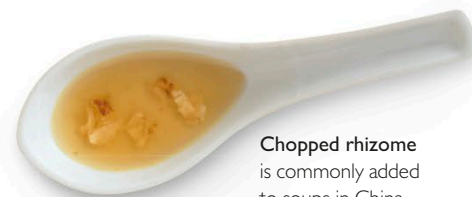
⚠ **Cautions** Do not take during pregnancy or while breastfeeding. Should not be used for heavy menstrual bleeding, bleeding disorders, and diarrhea. May interact with prescribed blood-thinning medication.



Tonic wine Make with *dong quai* and other tonic or bitter herbs (see p. 293). To improve vitality, drink a ¾ cup (150 ml) daily.



Tincture (to make, p. 292). For period pain, take ½ tsp with water up to 4 times a day.



Chopped rhizome is commonly added to soups in China.



Infusion For poor circulation, infuse 1 tsp with ¾ cup (150 ml) water (see p. 291). Drink ¾–1 ¼ cups (150–300 ml) a day.

🍲 **Decoction** (to make, p. 291). For anemia, take ¾ cup (150 ml) 2–3 times a day.

🍬 **Tablets** Take as a general female tonic.